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Graduate Recruitment Team

Houlihan Lokey

One Curzon Street

London W1J 5HD

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am applying for the 2027 Graduate Financial Analyst – Corporate Finance (M&A) role in London. I am a final-year Economics student at the University of Strathclyde, graduating in summer 2027 with a predicted 2:1. Houlihan Lokey's deal volume, which made it LSEG's number one adviser by number of global M&A transactions in 2025, promises the breadth of live deal exposure I am looking for from the start.

My clearest preparation for banking has been taking transactions apart. As co-founder and Treasurer of the Strathclyde Agricapital Society, the university's first agri-finance society, I grew membership to 126 and led weekly research sessions on deals such as Olam Agri's USD 1.24bn stake sale to SALIC, explaining the strategic rationale, the deal structure and the valuation to members, including many from outside finance. My strongest academic results are in the same territory: 90% in first-year Finance and 78%, the second-highest mark, in a third-year group project for Advanced Corporate Finance and Financial Markets.

Investment banking appeals to me because every transaction is a chain of judgements about who should buy, why now and at what price, and each one has to survive scrutiny from clients and counterparties. The analyst's part in that chain is accuracy under deadline, a habit I have built outside the classroom. For nearly two years at KONG, I reconciled end-of-shift cash and card takings while studying full-time. I now run the drinks programme as Head Mixologist at Le Set, a new 200-cover Glasgow venue, where I wrote the batch specifications and trained around 15 bar staff to standards that have to hold when someone else executes them.

Houlihan Lokey's corporate finance practice stands out to me because of its sheer deal flow: LSEG ranked it the number one adviser for global M&A by deal count in 2025, with 458 transactions. A mid-market focus means analysts see many deals from start to finish rather than a narrow slice of a few, and that is how I have learned best, by breaking down one transaction after another for Agricapital Society members until the patterns in rationale, structure and valuation became clear.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Will McGowan